THE HALAL FOOD COMPANION

81 Cities · 5 Must-Try Dishes in Each

Middle East & Gulf · Türkiye · Balkans · North Africa · Central Asia
South & Southeast Asia · East Africa · Thailand · India · Russia

From the skylines of the Gulf to the bazaars of Central Asia, the islands of the Indian Ocean to the mosques of the Balkans — a city-by-city guide for the curious Muslim traveler and anyone who loves these remarkable places.

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MIDDLE EAST AND GULF

Dubai, UAE

1. **Emirati machboos** — spiced rice with slow-cooked meat or fish, the national comfort dish.
2. **Luqaimat** — golden fried dough balls drizzled with date syrup, best eaten hot.
3. **Al harees** — silky wheat-and-meat porridge, a Ramadan and wedding classic.
4. **Shawarma** — Dubai's street-food king, carved fresh off the spit into warm bread.
5. **Knafeh** — molten cheese under crisp pastry threads, soaked in syrup.

Abu Dhabi, UAE

1. **Thareed** — tender meat and vegetables layered over broth-soaked flatbread.
2. **Balaleet** — sweet saffron vermicelli crowned with a savoury omelette; breakfast royalty.
3. **Grilled hammour** — the Gulf's beloved grouper, simply grilled with lemon and spices.
4. **Harees** — Abu Dhabi's heritage wheat dish, slow-beaten until creamy.
5. **Dates and gahwa** — fresh khalas dates with cardamom coffee, the eternal welcome.

Sharjah, UAE

1. **Chebab** — Emirati saffron pancakes served with cream cheese and date syrup.
2. **Machboos samak** — spiced fish rice, the coastal Emirati staple.
3. **Samboosa** — crisp triangular pastries, the Gulf's answer to the samosa.
4. **Regag bread** — paper-thin crispy bread from heritage souk griddles.
5. **Karak tea** — strong, sweet, milky tea; Sharjah runs on it.

AlUla, Saudi Arabia

1. **Kabsa** — Saudi Arabia's iconic spiced rice with chicken or lamb.
2. **Jareesh** — crushed-wheat porridge with yoghurt and caramelised onions.
3. **Margoog** — hearty stew with torn flatbread simmered into the sauce.
4. **AlUla dates** — fresh from the oasis, among the finest in the Kingdom.
5. **Saudi coffee with cardamom** — poured endlessly in every majlis.

Jeddah, Saudi Arabia

1. **Saleeg** — Hejazi creamy white rice cooked in milk and broth, topped with chicken.
2. **Mutabbaq** — the famous stuffed pancake of the old town, sweet or savoury.

3. **Sayadieh** — spiced fish and rice from the Red Sea catch.
4. **Ful and tamees** — fava beans with fluffy tandoor flatbread, Jeddah's breakfast.
5. **Grilled Red Sea shrimp** — straight from the fish market to the grill.

Riyadh, Saudi Arabia

1. **Najdi kabsa** — the capital's definitive plate of spiced rice and meat.
2. **Jareesh** — crushed wheat with yoghurt, beloved Najdi comfort food.
3. **Matazeez** — hand-pressed wheat dumplings in rich tomato-meat sauce.
4. **Kleeja** — cardamom-spiced wheat cookies from Qassim, perfect with coffee.
5. **Gursan** — thin bread soaked in meat broth until silky.

Abha, Saudi Arabia

1. **Haneeth** — lamb slow-roasted in an underground pit with mountain herbs.
2. **Areeka** — warm mashed bread with ghee, dates, and honey — Asir's dessert crown.
3. **Aseeda** — soft wheat dough with ghee and honey, eaten by hand.
4. **Mifa bread** — griddled Asiri flatbread with ghee.
5. **Asiri honey** — prized mountain honey, best over fresh bread and cream.

Al Ahsa, Saudi Arabia

1. **Hassawi red rice** — the oasis's own rice, nutty and aromatic, with chicken or fish.
2. **Khalas dates** — the famous soft caramel dates of the oasis.
3. **Machboos dajaj** — spiced chicken rice, eastern-province style.
4. **Maamoul** — date-filled semolina cookies from the souk ovens.
5. **Kleeja hassawiya** — the oasis's spiced biscuit with coffee.

Dammam, Saudi Arabia

1. **Shrimp machboos** — Gulf shrimp over spiced rice, the coast on a plate.
2. **Grilled hammour** — fresh grouper from the fish market.
3. **Kabsa** — the national dish, done eastern style.
4. **Harees** — creamy wheat and meat, a Ramadan favourite.
5. **Luqaimat** — syrup-drenched dough balls from corniche stalls.

Doha, Qatar

1. **Machboos** — Qatar's spiced rice national dish with chicken, lamb, or fish.
2. **Harees** — velvet-smooth wheat and chicken, a heritage dish.
3. **Thareed** — bread soaked in rich stew, the "Qatari lasagna."
4. **Luqaimat** — crisp syrup dumplings, Souq Waqif's favourite sweet.

5. **Karak tea** — the spiced milk tea that fuels Doha's evenings.

Muscat, Oman

1. **Shuwa** — lamb marinated and slow-cooked underground for a day; Oman's pride.
2. **Mashuai** — roast kingfish with lemon rice.
3. **Mishkak** — charcoal-grilled marinated beef skewers, Omani street food.
4. **Omani halwa** — saffron-rosewater confection served with coffee.
5. **Kahwa** — pale cardamom coffee, poured as a welcome everywhere.

Salalah, Oman

1. **Madhbi** — meat grilled on hot river stones, Dhofar's signature.
2. **Camel mishkak** — tender camel skewers, a local delicacy.
3. **Shuwa** — the slow pit-roasted lamb of festive Dhofar.
4. **Coconut everything** — fresh coconut from roadside stalls in this tropical corner.
5. **Dhofari halwa** — rich with ghee and nuts, served with bitter coffee.

Manama, Bahrain

1. **Machboos** — Bahrain's spiced rice, the everyday national dish.
2. **Muhammar** — sweet rice served with fried fish; sweet-savoury magic.
3. **Bamia** — okra and lamb stew, comfort in a bowl.
4. **Samboosa** — crisp pastries from the Manama Souq stalls.
5. **Bahraini halwa** — sticky saffron sweet from the old sweet shops of Muharraq.

Kuwait City, Kuwait

1. **Machboos zubaidi** — spiced rice with the beloved pomfret fish.
2. **Mutabbaq samak** — slow-cooked fish over caramelised onion rice.
3. **Gers ogaily** — saffron and cardamom sponge cake with sesame.
4. **Gabout** — flour dumplings stuffed with meat in broth.
5. **Harees** — smooth wheat porridge, the taste of Kuwaiti Ramadan.

Amman, Jordan

1. **Mansaf** — Jordan's national dish: lamb in fermented yoghurt sauce over rice.
2. **Hashem's falafel** — the legendary downtown falafel and hummus feast.
3. **Habibah's knafeh** — hot cheese pastry worth the queue.
4. **Musakhan** — sumac chicken over taboon bread with caramelised onions.
5. **Maqluba** — the "upside-down" rice, flipped theatrically at the table.

Aqaba, Jordan

1. **Sayadieh** — Aqaba's signature: spiced fish over caramelised onion rice.
2. **Grilled Red Sea fish** — choose it at the market, eat it by the water.
3. **Mixed grill mezze** — kebabs, hummus, and fresh bread by the marina.
4. **Mansaf** — the national dish, served in the town's Jordanian kitchens.
5. **Knafeh** — the perfect finish after a day on the reef.

Baku, Azerbaijan

1. **Shah plov** — saffron rice with lamb, dried fruit, and chestnuts under a bread crust.
2. **Qutab** — thin griddled pancakes stuffed with greens or meat.
3. **Dushbara** — tiny lamb dumplings in clear broth, a spoonful each.
4. **Lyulya kebab** — minced lamb grilled on wide skewers over coals.
5. **Pakhlava** — Baku's diamond-cut baklava with saffron and nuts.

Ganja, Azerbaijan

1. **Dovga** — warm yoghurt soup with herbs and rice, Ganja's comfort bowl.
2. **Dushbara** — tiny dumplings, said to be best in Ganja.
3. **Kufta-bozbash** — giant meatball soup with chickpeas and plum.
4. **Lula kebab** — smoky minced lamb with lavash and sumac onions.
5. **Ganja pakhlava** — local-style layered nut pastry.

TÜRKIYE

Istanbul, Türkiye

1. **Turkish breakfast** — a feast of cheeses, olives, honey, kaymak, eggs, and endless tea.
2. **Döner kebab** — the vertical rotisserie that conquered the world, born in this city.
3. **Balik ekmek** — grilled fish sandwich by the Galata Bridge.
4. **Simit** — sesame-crusted bread rings, Istanbul's daily bread.
5. **Baklava** — Karaköy's pistachio layers, the city's sweetest legacy.

Cappadocia / Göreme, Türkiye

1. **Testi kebab** — meat and vegetables slow-cooked in a sealed clay pot, cracked open at your table.
2. **Manti** — tiny Anatolian dumplings with yoghurt and chilli butter.
3. **Gözleme** — hand-rolled flatbread stuffed with cheese and greens.
4. **Pottery beans** — kuru fasulye baked in clay pots, a village classic.
5. **Dried apricot desserts** — from the region's famous orchards.

Antalya, Türkiye

1. **Antalya piyaz** — white bean salad with tahini, unique to this city.
2. **Şiş köfte** — Antalya's grilled minced-meat skewers.
3. **Hibeş** — lemony tahini-cumin meze of the Mediterranean coast.
4. **Tandır kebab** — slow-roasted lamb falling off the bone.
5. **Kabak tatlısı** — candied pumpkin with tahini and walnuts.

Bodrum, Türkiye

1. **Çökertme kebabı** — Bodrum's own: veal strips over crispy potatoes with garlic yoghurt.
2. **Grilled Aegean fish** — levrek or çipura, simply grilled at the marina.
3. **Aegean mezes** — herb salads, octopus, and olive-oil dishes.
4. **Gözleme** — village griddled flatbreads at the markets.
5. **Mandarin lokma** — syrup doughnuts scented with Bodrum mandarins.

Pamukkale, Türkiye

1. **Denizli tandır kebab** — pit-roasted lamb, famous across Türkiye.
2. **Keşkek** — ceremonial wheat-and-meat paste, UNESCO-listed heritage.
3. **Çöp şiş** — tiny grilled skewers from the region's barbecue houses.
4. **Bazlama** — fluffy village flatbread with butter and cheese.

5. **Village breakfast** — farmhouse spreads in the valleys around the travertines.

Fethiye, Türkiye

1. **Fish market dinner** — pick your fish, the surrounding restaurants grill it.
2. **Grilled calamari** — Fethiye's kalamar is famous.
3. **Pide** — canoe-shaped Turkish pizza from wood ovens.
4. **Gözleme** — made by village women at roadside stands.
5. **Fresh mezes** — olive-oil vegetables and yoghurt dips of the Lycian coast.

Izmir, Türkiye

1. **Boyoz** — flaky, buttery pastry, Izmir's breakfast icon.
2. **Kumru** — the famous sesame-bread sandwich of Çeşme.
3. **İzmir köfte** — meatballs baked with tomato and peppers.
4. **Gevrek** — Izmir's crispier answer to simit, with tea on the Kordon.
5. **Şambali** — semolina-almond street dessert with clotted cream.

Trabzon, Türkiye

1. **Akçaabat köfte** — garlicky grilled meatballs, the region's pride.
2. **Kuymak (mıhlama)** — molten cheese and cornmeal, stretched gloriously.
3. **Hamsi** — Black Sea anchovies, fried, grilled, or baked in rice.
4. **Trabzon pidesi** — boat-shaped pide with butter and egg.
5. **Laz böreği** — custard-filled pastry, the sweet of the Black Sea.

Bursa, Türkiye

1. **İskender kebab** — döner over bread with tomato sauce and browned butter, invented here.
2. **Cantık** — Bursa's small meat pide.
3. **Kestane şekeri** — candied chestnuts, the city's sweet symbol.
4. **Kemalpaşa tatlısı** — syrupy cheese dessert of the Bursa region.
5. **Village breakfast in Cumalıkızık** — homemade everything in a 700-year-old village.

Marmaris, Türkiye

1. **Grilled sea bream** — harbour-fresh, by the marina.
2. **Pine honey** — Marmaris produces most of Türkiye's famous pine honey.
3. **Köfte** — grilled meatballs in the old-town lokantas.
4. **Pide and lahmacun** — wood-fired favourites after boat days.
5. **Meze spreads** — olive-oil dishes and salads with pine-scented air.

Alanya, Türkiye

1. **Grilled fish** — straight off the harbour boats.
2. **Gözleme** — cheese-and-potato flatbreads of the Taurus villages.
3. **Alanya köfte** — local grilled meatballs with mountain herbs.
4. **Fresh pomegranate and orange juice** — from the region's orchards.
5. **Baklava** — pistachio layers at the harbour patisseries.

Konya, Türkiye

1. **Etli ekmek** — long, thin "bread with meat," Konya's answer to pizza.
2. **Fırın kebabı** — oven-roasted lamb, tender for a reason: centuries of practice.
3. **Tandır** — clay-oven lamb with warm flatbread.
4. **Bamya çorbası** — okra soup, a Seljuk-era wedding dish.
5. **Höşmerim** — creamy cheese-semolina dessert of the region.

Ankara, Türkiye

1. **Ankara döner** — the capital's own döner tradition.
2. **Beypazarı güveç** — slow-baked lamb stew from the nearby Ottoman town.
3. **Simit** — Ankara claims the crunchiest in Türkiye.
4. **Tahinli çörek** — swirled tahini pastry from Beypazarı ovens.
5. **Aşure** — Noah's pudding, the sweet of grains, fruits, and blessing.

BALKANS

Kotor, Montenegro

1. **Black risotto** — cuttlefish-ink rice, the bay's signature.
2. **Grilled calamari** — stuffed or plain, straight from the Adriatic.
3. **Buzara mussels** — shellfish in garlic, wine-free tomato broth on request.
4. **Grilled sea bass** — the catch of the day in waterfront konobas.
5. **Priganice** — honey-drizzled dough puffs of the Montenegrin coast.

Budva, Montenegro

1. **Grilled Adriatic fish** — sea bass and bream at the harbour.
2. **Seafood risotto** — the Riviera staple.
3. **Octopus salad** — light, lemony, and fresh.
4. **Ćevapi** — grilled minced-meat fingers in flatbread.
5. **Baklava** — the Ottoman sweet legacy of the coast.

Podgorica, Montenegro

1. **Kačamak** — creamy potato-cornmeal mash with cheese and kaymak.
2. **Grilled lamb** — mountain lamb at its simplest and best.
3. **Cicvara** — rich cornmeal porridge with cheese, highland comfort.
4. **Burek** — flaky meat pie from the old-town bakeries.
5. **Baklava** — syrupy layers from the Stara Varoš sweet shops.

Mostar, Bosnia and Herzegovina

1. **Ćevapi** — Mostar's smoky grilled fingers in warm somun.
2. **Begova čorba** — the "bey's soup," creamy chicken and okra.
3. **Burek** — spiral meat pie, king of Bosnian bakeries.
4. **Tufahije** — poached apples with walnut cream.
5. **Baklava** — with Bosnian coffee in the old bazaar.

Sarajevo, Bosnia and Herzegovina

1. **Ćevapi u somunu** — the definitive Bosnian plate, in Baščaršija where it belongs.
2. **Burek** — Sarajevo's flaky, juicy meat pie.
3. **Begova čorba** — slow chicken soup of the Ottoman courts.
4. **Tufahija** — walnut-stuffed poached apple in syrup.
5. **Bosnian coffee with rahat lokum** — the ritual that defines the city.

Ohrid, North Macedonia

1. **Ohrid trout** — the famous lake fish, grilled by the shore.
2. **Tavče gravče** — baked beans in clay pots, the national comfort dish.
3. **Gjomleze** — layered baked pastry of the Ohrid region.
4. **Ajvar** — roasted red-pepper relish, spread on everything.
5. **Trileçe** — three-milk cake, the Balkans' favourite dessert.

Skopje, North Macedonia

1. **Tavče gravče** — clay-pot beans, Skopje's soul food.
2. **Kebapi** — grilled minced meat with onions and flatbread.
3. **Sarma** — cabbage rolls of the home kitchens.
4. **Burek** — from the Old Bazaar's bakeries.
5. **Baklava** — syrupy layers from the bazaar's sweet shops.

Tetovo, North Macedonia

1. **Flija** — the layered "mountain pancake," baked slowly under an iron lid.
2. **Qebapa** — Tetovo's famous grilled minced-meat kebabs.
3. **Tavë kosi** — lamb baked in yoghurt, Albania's beloved dish.
4. **Burek** — flaky and hot from every bakery.
5. **Baklava** — the sweet finish of the Šar Mountain tables.

Tirana, Albania

1. **Byrek** — flaky spinach or meat pie, Albania's daily bread.
2. **Tavë kosi** — the national baked lamb-and-yoghurt dish.
3. **Fërgesë** — baked peppers, tomato, and cottage cheese, Tirana's own.
4. **Qofte** — herb-flecked grilled meatballs.
5. **Trileçe** — the three-milk cake that conquered the Balkans.

Prizren, Kosovo

1. **Qebapa** — Prizren calls itself Kosovo's grill capital; taste why.
2. **Flija** — the slow-baked layered specialty.
3. **Sarma** — vine or cabbage rolls with minced meat.
4. **Burek** — Shadervan square's bakeries set the standard.
5. **Baklava** — from generations-old sweet shops.

Pristina, Kosovo

1. **Qebapa** — the grill houses of the capital never disappoint.
2. **Flija** — layered and slow-baked, worth the wait.
3. **Byrek** — the breakfast of the entire city.

4. **Trileçe** — Pristina's patisserie pride.
5. **Macchiato** — famously among the best coffee in Europe.

NORTH AFRICA

Marrakesh, Morocco

1. **Lamb tagine** — slow-cooked with apricots and almonds under the conical lid.
2. **Friday couscous** — the weekly mountain of semolina, vegetables, and broth.
3. **Tanjia** — Marrakesh's own: meat slow-cooked for hours in a clay urn.
4. **Harira** — tomato-lentil soup that breaks the fast.
5. **Msemen with mint tea** — square griddled pancakes with honey.

Essaouira, Morocco

1. **Grilled sardines** — port-side, charcoal-fresh, unforgettable.
2. **Seafood tagine** — the Atlantic catch under Moroccan spices.
3. **Grilled calamari** — from the boat to your plate in an hour.
4. **Amlou** — argan oil, almond, and honey spread — Essaouira's gold.
5. **Mint tea on the ramparts** — the ritual, with an ocean view.

Tangier, Morocco

1. **Fish tagine** — the Strait's catch with chermoula spices.
2. **Pastilla** — the sweet-savoury pigeon (or chicken) pie of Fassi tradition.
3. **Bissara** — silky fava-bean soup with cumin and olive oil.
4. **Harira** — the hearty soup of Ramadan evenings.
5. **Mint tea at Café Hafa** — since 1921, above the sea.

Rabat, Morocco

1. **Pastilla** — crisp layers, savoury filling, dusted sugar and cinnamon.
2. **Couscous** — Friday's mountain of semolina in the medina homes.
3. **Tagine kefta** — spiced meatballs with eggs poached in tomato.
4. **Grilled sardines** — Bouregreg river-mouth style.
5. **Cornes de gazelle** — almond-paste crescents, Morocco's elegant cookie.

Casablanca, Morocco

1. **Seafood tagine** — Atlantic fish and prawns with chermoula.
2. **Grilled fish at the port** — pick it, weigh it, eat it.
3. **Couscous** — done rich and generous, Casablanca style.
4. **Harira with chebakia** — soup and sesame-honey coils at sunset.
5. **Moroccan salads** — a dozen small plates before the main.

Cairo, Egypt

1. **Koshary** — the national bowl: rice, lentils, pasta, crispy onions, garlic vinegar.
2. **Ful and taameya** — fava beans and Egyptian falafel, breakfast of the pharaohs.
3. **Molokhia** — the green jute-leaf stew, garlicky and rich.
4. **Mahshi** — vegetables stuffed with herbed rice.
5. **Kunafa** — Cairo's crisp, syrupy Ramadan dessert.

Alexandria, Egypt

1. **Kebda iskandarani** — Alexandrian liver, fiery with garlic and chilli.
2. **Grilled sea bass** — the Mediterranean catch at Anfushi.
3. **Sayadiyah** — fishermen's spiced fish and rice.
4. **Shrimp casserole** — baked in tomato and garlic.
5. **Feteer meshaltet** — the layered "Egyptian pancake" with honey.

Sharm El Sheikh, Egypt

1. **Grilled Red Sea fish** — the day's catch by the marina.
2. **Sayadiyah** — the Red Sea fishermen's rice dish.
3. **Bedouin zarb** — meat slow-cooked in desert sand ovens.
4. **Koshary** — Egypt's beloved bowl, even at the resort.
5. **Kunafa** — syrupy threads after a day on the reef.

Hurghada, Egypt

1. **Grilled fish** — grouper and snapper from the local boats.
2. **Seafood sayadiyah** — Hurghada's signature rice.
3. **Bedouin dinner** — grilled meats and fresh bread under desert stars.
4. **Koshary** — cheap, cheerful, and everywhere.
5. **Sugarcane juice** — pressed fresh at the juice stands.

Tunis, Tunisia

1. **Brik** — crisp pastry with a runny egg inside; eat it over the plate.
2. **Couscous with fish** — the coastal Tunisian way.
3. **Ojja** — eggs poached in spicy tomato sauce.
4. **Lablabi** — chickpea soup over torn bread, Tunis's soul food.
5. **Makroudh** — semolina date diamonds fried in oil.

Djerba, Tunisia

1. **Octopus couscous** — the island's proud signature.
2. **Grilled fish** — from Houmt Souk's morning catch.

3. **Brik** — the island's crisp egg pastry.
4. **Harissa mezze** — the fiery red paste of Tunisia, tamed with olive oil.
5. **Dates and mint tea** — Djerba's palm-grove close.

Sousse, Tunisia

1. **Couscous** — fluffy semolina with lamb or fish.
2. **Grilled sardines** — Sahel-coast style.
3. **Ojja** — spicy tomato-and-egg skillet.
4. **Tajine tunisien** — the baked egg-and-meat "cake," unlike Morocco's.
5. **Makroudh** — date-filled semolina sweets.

CENTRAL ASIA

Samarkand, Uzbekistan

1. **Samarkand plov** — the city's layered plov, cooked in vast kazans.
2. **Non** — the famous stamped bread, carried home by the bagful.
3. **Samsa** — tandoor-baked meat pastries.
4. **Shashlik** — smoky skewers at Siyob Bazaar.
5. **Samarkand halva** — dense, nutty, unforgettable.

Bukhara, Uzbekistan

1. **Bukhara plov** — the ancient city's own take on the national dish.
2. **Shashlik** — lamb skewers beside Lyabi Hauz.
3. **Samsa** — crisp from the tandoor.
4. **Lagman** — hand-pulled noodle soup.
5. **Non** — Bukhara's golden, sesame-topped bread.

Tashkent, Uzbekistan

1. **Plov at Besh Qozon** — watch a tonne of plov cooked in one giant kazan.
2. **Lagman** — hand-pulled noodles, Tashkent's favourite bowl.
3. **Manti** — steamed dumplings with pumpkin or lamb.
4. **Samsa** — from Chorsu Bazaar's tandoors.
5. **Chuchvara** — tiny dumplings in broth.

Khiva, Uzbekistan

1. **Shivit oshi** — green dill noodles, unique to Khorezm.
2. **Tuhum barak** — delicate egg-filled dumplings.
3. **Gumma** — fried meat pies of the oasis.
4. **Khorezm plov** — with the region's famous yellow carrots.
5. **Melons** — Khorezm's legendary sweet melons in season.

Almaty, Kazakhstan

1. **Beshbarmak** — the national dish: boiled meat over wide noodles, "five fingers."
2. **Kazy** — horse-meat sausage, the festive delicacy.
3. **Baursak** — golden fried dough puffs.
4. **Lagman** — Dungan-style noodles, a city favourite.
5. **Plov** — Green Bazaar's kazans never stop.

Astana, Kazakhstan

1. **Beshbarmak** — the Kazakh table's centrepiece.
2. **Baursak with kaymak** — fried dough with clotted cream.
3. **Kazy** — horse sausage, sliced cold.
4. **Manti** — steamed dumplings with sour cream.
5. **Shelpek** — crispy fried flatbread of the steppe.

Turkistan, Kazakhstan

1. **Plov** — served generously to pilgrims for centuries.
2. **Beshbarmak** — the hospitality dish of the south.
3. **Samsa** — tandoor pastries at the bazaar.
4. **Baursak** — golden puffs with tea.
5. **Kymyz** — fermented mare's milk, the ancient steppe drink.

Shymkent, Kazakhstan

1. **Shymkent plov** — locals swear theirs is Kazakhstan's best.
2. **Samsa** — from street-corner tandoors.
3. **Shashlik** — southern-style skewers.
4. **Lagman** — the Uzbek-Kazakh noodle bowl.
5. **Beshbarmak** — hospitality on a platter.

Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan

1. **Beshbarmak** — Kyrgyzstan's nomadic national dish.
2. **Lagman** — hand-pulled noodles, Dungan heritage.
3. **Manti** — steamed to perfection at Osh Bazaar.
4. **Boorsok** — fried dough of the yurt tables.
5. **Kymyz** — mare's milk, the taste of the jailoo pastures.

Dushanbe, Tajikistan

1. **Qurutob** — the national dish: bread soaked in yoghurt sauce with onions and herbs.
2. **Osh (plov)** — Tajikistan's rice pilaf with yellow carrots.
3. **Lagman** — noodle soup of the chaikhanas.
4. **Sambusa** — baked pastries with greens or meat.
5. **Non with chay** — bread and tea, the Tajik ritual.

SOUTHEAST AND SOUTH ASIA

Bali, Indonesia

1. **Halal nasi goreng** — Indonesia's fried rice, at Muslim-owned warungs across the island.
2. **Jimbaran grilled seafood** — fish, prawns, and calamari grilled on the beach at sunset.
3. **Sate lilit ikan** — Balinese spiced fish satay wrapped around lemongrass sticks.
4. **Ayam betutu** — slow-roasted spiced chicken, Bali's ceremonial dish (choose chicken, not duck or pork, versions).
5. **Pisang goreng** — crispy fried bananas with palm-sugar drizzle.

Yogyakarta, Indonesia

1. **Gudeg** — the sweet jackfruit stew that defines Jogja, with chicken and egg.
2. **Sate klathak** — minimalist lamb satay grilled on iron skewers.
3. **Nasi kucing** — "cat rice" parcels from the angkringan street carts.
4. **Bakpia** — sweet mung-bean pastries, the city's gift-box staple.
5. **Wedang ronde** — warm ginger drink with glutinous rice balls, for cool evenings.

Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia

1. **Nasi lemak** — coconut rice with sambal, anchovies, egg, and peanuts; the national breakfast.
2. **Satay** — charcoal skewers with peanut sauce, best at Kampung Baru.
3. **Roti canai** — flaky griddled flatbread with dhal, the mamak-stall icon.
4. **Curry laksa** — rich coconut-noodle soup.
5. **Cendol** — shaved ice with pandan noodles and palm sugar.

Penang, Malaysia

1. **Nasi kandar** — Penang-born Muslim Indian rice drowned in mixed curries.
2. **Assam laksa** — sour, fishy, fiery; ranked among the world's best dishes.
3. **Char kway teow** — smoky wok-fried noodles (many halal-certified stalls).
4. **Mee sotong** — mamak noodles with squid sambal at the Esplanade.
5. **Penang cendol** — the famous Lebuh Keng Kwee bowl.

Langkawi, Malaysia

1. **Grilled seafood** — beach shacks serve the Andaman catch, all halal.
2. **Laksa Kedah** — the state of Kedah's own rice-noodle laksa.

3. **Satay** — night-market skewers with peanut sauce.
4. **Nasi lemak** — the breakfast you will crave daily.
5. **Kuih** — colourful Malay cakes from the rotating pasar malam.

Malé, Maldives

1. **Mas huni** — tuna, coconut, onion, and chilli with roshi flatbread; the national breakfast.
2. **Garudhiya** — clear fish broth with rice, lime, and chilli.
3. **Masroshi** — stuffed tuna-coconut flatbread.
4. **Maldivian fish curry (riha)** — tuna simmered in coconut and spice.
5. **Hedhikaa** — the afternoon "short eats" of the local cafés.

Baa Atoll, Maldives

1. **Mas huni** — the island breakfast, best with fresh roshi.
2. **Tuna curry** — the Maldives runs on its pole-caught tuna.
3. **Grilled reef fish** — caught at sunset, grilled under the stars.
4. **Roshi and rihaakuru** — flatbread with the famous fish paste.
5. **Coconut desserts** — island sweets of coconut and palm honey.

Hunza Valley, Pakistan

1. **Chapshuro** — the valley's meat-filled "Hunza pie," griddled golden.
2. **Dawdo soup** — apricot-oil noodle soup, the winter warmer.
3. **Gyal pancakes** — buckwheat pancakes with apricot oil.
4. **Dried apricots and mulberries** — the valley's famous harvest.
5. **Walnut cake** — Karimabad cafés' beloved slice with mountain tea.

Skardu, Pakistan

1. **Mamtu** — Balti steamed dumplings, the region's signature.
2. **Balay** — hearty noodle soup of the Balti mountains.
3. **Apricot dishes** — soup, oil, and preserves from the orchards.
4. **Grilled trout** — cold-stream fish of the northern valleys.
5. **Butter tea and Balti bread** — the mountain breakfast.

EAST AFRICA

Zanzibar City / Stone Town, Tanzania

1. **Zanzibar pizza** — the folded, griddled street "pizza" of Forodhani Gardens.
2. **Urojo** — the famous "Zanzibar mix" soup with mango, bhajia, and cassava.
3. **Mishkaki** — Swahili marinated meat skewers.
4. **Octopus curry** — coconut-rich, a taste of the Swahili coast.
5. **Pilau ya kuku** — spice-island chicken pilau, fragrant with cloves.

THAILAND

Satun, Thailand

1. **Khao mok gai** — Thai-Muslim chicken biryani with crispy shallots.
2. **Roti mataba** — stuffed crispy roti, the south's favourite.
3. **Sup hang wua** — rich oxtail soup of the Muslim south.
4. **Grilled seafood** — the Andaman catch at Pak Bara's stalls.
5. **Roti with teh tarik** — the sweet ending of every Satun evening.

Koh Lanta, Thailand

1. **Massaman curry** — the southern Muslim curry, rich with potato and peanut.
2. **Grilled fish** — from the Muslim fishing villages of the old town.
3. **Khao mok gai** — southern chicken biryani, island style.
4. **Roti** — banana or egg, made by Lanta's Muslim roti masters.
5. **Seafood BBQ** — beachside grills from Klong Dao to Kantiang.

INDIA

Kozhikode, India

1. **Kozhikode biryani** — light, fragrant, and legendary across India.
2. **Kozhikode halwa** — the glossy sweet of SM Street's halwa shops.
3. **Unnakaya** — banana fritters stuffed with coconut and egg.
4. **Pathiri with chicken curry** — Malabar's thin rice bread and rich curry.
5. **Sulaimani** — spiced lemon tea, the perfect Malabar finish.

Lakshadweep, India

1. **Mas (tuna) dishes** — dried and fresh tuna, the islands' lifeblood.
2. **Coconut fish curry** — lagoon fish in island coconut milk.
3. **Grilled reef fish** — your catch, grilled on the beach.
4. **Rice with coconut roti** — the island staple.
5. **Banana fritters** — sweet island snacks with evening tea.

Hyderabad, India

1. **Hyderabadi biryani** — the kacchi-style dum biryani, India's most famous.
2. **Haleem** — the slow-pounded wheat-meat delicacy of Ramadan.
3. **Irani chai with Osmania biscuits** — the old city's ritual.
4. **Shami kebab** — silken lentil-meat patties of the Nizam's tables.
5. **Qubani ka meetha** — apricot dessert with cream.

Lucknow, India

1. **Galouti kebab** — the melt-in-the-mouth kebab of Tunday Kababi.
2. **Lucknowi biryani** — the subtle, fragrant Awadhi style.
3. **Nihari** — slow-cooked shank stew, breakfast of Nawabs.
4. **Sheermal** — saffron flatbread of the Awadhi court.
5. **Kulfi** — dense, creamy, pistachio-topped.

RUSSIA

Kazan, Russia

1. **Echpochmak** — the triangular Tatar pie of meat, potato, and onion.
2. **Chak-chak** — honey-drenched fried dough, Tatarstan's celebration sweet.
3. **Kystyby** — griddled flatbread with mashed potato.
4. **Kazy** — Tatar horse sausage, the festive table's pride.
5. **Talkysh kaleve** — spun-honey pyramids, the Kazan delicacy.